

Women in Boardrooms

MOST POWERFUL WOMEN - 2025

“Over time, they recognise the value a woman brings, and that could take two-three years. The perspective through which you look at gender changes,” she adds.

Of course, the stage of a company makes a difference. More mature companies have more women on their boards.

Sonu Bhasin, an independent director and business historian, feels the size of the company is crucial. “The attitude of the promoter (in a promoter-led company) or the Chairman/MD (in a non-promoter-driven company) determines the composition of the board, including women representation,” she says. Bhasin—who sits on multiple boards, including Berger Paints, Triveni Turbines, Nippon Life India Asset Management, Multi Commodity Exchange of India and NIIT—picks 2014 as the starting point and acknowledges that a large distance has been covered in terms of women’s representation in boardrooms.

“The obvious hits include more women directors than in 2014. The misses include the fact that there are still many companies, including a large number of public sector undertakings, that do not have a woman director,” says Bhasin.

CONNECTIONS MATTER

It is relevant to understand how much the mindset has changed with respect to women’s representation on boards over time. This is best demonstrated through numbers, with Khaitan & Co’s report stating that the 2013 mandate has driven “nearly universal compliance” among BSE 200 companies.

The report points to early concerns that the mandate will make organisations hire women they know, including family members and friends, instead of promoting true diversity. “Today, among the BSE 200 companies, only 10% women directors are related to other members of their boards,” it says.

Sukanya Hazarika, Director of Khaitan & Co, does not hesitate to call the 2013 mandate “affirmative action.” The challenge, she says, revolves around the relatively small pool of experienced women directors. Consequently, the role of networking becomes disproportionately critical. Interviews conducted for the report highlight that close to 97% view it as important. External networks (such as relationships with clients, mentors and women’s leadership groups) serve as the most powerful gateway to the boardroom.

“Building these connections begins early in one’s career, and that is sustained over time, rather than being limited to periods when individuals are actively seeking

The Critical Imbalance



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board positions. Even women with strong professional credentials, such as CXOs often depend on allies to boost visibility and credibility in male-dominated networks,” says the report.

Inevitably, women with strong networking skills, through their trusted circles, are recommended for board roles. The report mentions a director who recounts how a former boss recognised her potential and directly recom-